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STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Reading the Renaissance

Grades 5–8 · ELA

ADMIT ONE

NAME	DATE	CLASS

Challenge context: The Harlem Renaissance was one of the most significant cultural events in American history — and one of the least understood. It was not simply a celebration of Black talent; it was a deliberate, sophisticated, and sometimes contested attempt to use cultural achievement as a tool for social and political change. The figures who made it were artists AND activists, creators AND strategists.

01

ACTIVITY 1 · LITERATURE AS ACTIVISM

The Political Art of Writing

In the Harlem Renaissance, writing was not merely art — it was argument. W.E.B. Du Bois wrote in *The Crisis*: "We want to be Americans, full-fledged Americans, with all the social rights, the dignity, the freedom and the opportunity of Americans." Alain Locke argued that cultural achievement by Black Americans would force white America to reconsider its racial assumptions.

Evaluate this strategy: Was using cultural achievement as a civil rights argument effective? What were its strengths? What were its limitations?

02

ACTIVITY 2 · CLOSE READING

Analyzing the New Negro

Alain Locke's anthology *The New Negro* (1925) is considered the manifesto of the Harlem Renaissance. Its central argument was that a "New Negro" had emerged — one who would no longer accept the racial stereotypes of the past but would define Black identity through cultural achievement.

What are the strengths of this argument as a strategy for social change?

What are its limitations? Who might it have excluded?

ACTIVITY 3 · YOUR MANIFESTO

03

Write What You Believe

The Harlem Renaissance writers wrote manifestos — statements of belief about what their art was for and why it mattered. Write your own short manifesto (8–12 sentences) about your own creative voice: What do you want to say? Who are you writing for? What do you refuse to do in your writing?

Write your manifesto here

Critical question: Du Bois famously wrote about the "double consciousness" of Black Americans — the sense of always seeing oneself through the eyes of others. Do you experience any form of double consciousness in your own writing — a tension between your natural voice and the voice you think you should use?

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Option 1 — Visit the exhibition: If the Harlem Renaissance exhibition is available at your school, visit the Mini Museum to experience the phonograph, Jazz Lab, Great Migration Map, and more. Ask your librarian to arrange a class visit.

Option 2 — Virtual visit: Explore the full exhibition at **minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance**

Research extension: Find and read Countee Cullen's poem "Heritage" and Langston Hughes's essay "The Negro Artist and the Racial Mountain." These two writers disagreed fundamentally about what Black writing should do. Write a paragraph explaining their disagreement and which position you find more compelling.